

Episode 7: Surely *Space Battleship Yamato* Was the Beginning

Due to my work, our house was piled with VHS videotapes. Various programmes recordings from TV, work reference footage, even white boxes (completed video dubbed to VHS tapes for staff use). They were all necessary, but they just took up space and were bothersome. In recent years, DVD recorders appeared on the market, and our house dutifully purchased one. We converted all the VHS tapes to DVD at once. We were able to clear them out beautifully.

The other day, when I returned to my parents' house, I looked up at my room's shelves for over ten minutes. There was a massive mountain of tapes. VHS plus 8mm video and beta tapes (laughs). And they're all treasure troves you can't easily throw away! Hmm... The road ahead is still long (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Let me take a break from collaborative work stories this time. An even older story.

Since buying that plastic model "1/350 Space Battleship Yamato" I mentioned, I've gotten fired up about *Space Battleship Yamato* again (laughs). I impulsively bought the first TV series DVD box set (well, I had it on laser disc), and I've been watching it obsessively lately. It's a bit of a "festival" state.

I was an elementary school student who liked anime at a normal kid level, but yes, in the fall of fifth grade, I encountered a certain anime. That was *Space Battleship Yamato*.

Everything about it was different from the anime I'd watched before, and man, I was hooked as a kid (laughs). Looking back, I think quite a lot of who I am today began with this encounter with *Space Battleship Yamato*. Starting to read lots of manga, getting interested in SF novels, buying and building plastic models, first wanting a

telescope after getting interested in astronomy - it all began when I was obsessed with *Space Battleship Yamato* around this time.

So this time, I'd like to write about *Space Battleship Yamato* from a "colour" perspective, fitting for "Colour Design Notes."

First, my favourite scenes (laughs).

Episode 1 - Nothing beats Captain Okita's monochrome-style colour change scene. The scene where he decides to retreat in the bridge of the damaged Okita ship under attack from the Gamilas fleet. In the alert-like red-toned background, the blue-grey feeling of Captain Okita calmly trying to make decisions really got to me. The designs and colours of the Gamilas battleship and assault ship **Yukikaze** (ゆきかぜ) that appeared in this episode are my No.1 favourites among *Space Battleship Yamato*'s design groups.

Episode 2 - **Yamato** appearing after shaking off the old battleship **Yamato**'s remains. The heavy colours of Yamato appearing against the dim ground surface background after sunset are great. As a child, I thought "Whoa!" at the colours and animation of the light reflection the ship body receives when firing the **Shock Cannon** (main gun).

Episode 3 - Yamato flying with the explosion smoke and flames of a super-large missile as background. This is probably cel book or harmony processing, but man, it's cool. For these "decisive!" cuts, you really want to put effort into showing them, and in my own work, I think I want to add an extra touch to cuts like this - that became my foundation.

Episode 4 - The footlight-style reflection colour changes in the strategy room explaining warp principles are cool. I still get excited by Yuki Mori's nude cut during warp (laughs).

Episode 5 - The wave cannon's high-contrast colours. "Strong light high-contrast can be just two-colour painting," I think, and this might be the root of such thoughts.

Episodes 7 & 8 - The light from Pluto's reflection satellite cannon and its reflection colours are nice. Yamato's main gun is green while Gamilas light weapons are pink-based. I really understood the necessity of this distinction after I started working. The processing of Pluto's indigenous life forms, probably cel doubling processing, has a blue-black transparency that feels like a planet far from the sun.

Episode 10 - **Dr. Sado's beloved cat Mii-kun** appearing in the final communication with Earth. I was really drawn to this very **Matsumoto**-style cat. Maybe this is the root of my cat-loving.

Episode 11 - Actually, from this episode, **Gamilas people's skin becomes blue**. Even the main character **Desler** has his skin and hair colours boldly changed! In previous episodes, they were the same as Earth people. This was probably to make them more alien-like and distinguish them from Earth people, but as a child I really thought "I wish it had been like that from Episode 1." Still, this major change mid-series was quite a bold decision, I think. We also make minor adjustments and minor changes in our own work, but we're too scared to do such bold full model changes (bitter laugh).

Episode 16 - The story where **Yuki Mori** and **Analyzer** are captured by **Beemera** people while investigating to gather vegetables. This episode uses special colouring throughout, but especially the colour change of Analyzer standing alone against the burning Beemera planet city background is impressive. With overall dark shadow-like colours and only the instruments appearing to glow, that figure is full of melancholy, and Analyzer's sadness comes through in the colours.

Episode 25 - **Starsha's** hair is colour trace finishing, right... or so I thought, but looking closely this time, ah, Starsha's eyes and face contours and other skin main lines themselves are basically colour trace? Or brown carbon trace processing! This kind of processing takes a lot of effort! But thanks to this processing, she becomes a somehow mystical character. Probably because Starsha appeared in few episodes, they could manage such time-consuming processing.

Episode 26 - The final episode begins immediately without the usual opening, making me keenly feel "Ah, it's the final episode!" - that memory remains vividly today. Having the opening or ending spill into the main episode gives a real "special episode" feeling. I experienced this as a creator with *Ojamajo Doremi* and *Gaiking* endings, but this is quite troublesome in various ways - money (production costs) issues, problems with stations and agencies (laughs).

When I watch this *Yamato* after starting animation finishing work, I can't help noticing finishing retake cuts. Back then it was cel finishing, and probably there wasn't enough time to process retakes.

In space and other dark backgrounds, cel scratches, dust, and dirt inevitably stand out, and countless cuts with surface painting for colour error corrections and colour mismatches are visible. Well, that probably also became part of *Yamato*'s "flavour."

About Space Battleship *Yamato* itself's colours. Actually, the colours in the three theatrical versions produced by Toei Doga - *Farewell Space Battleship Yamato: Warriors of Love*, *Yamato Forever*, *Space Battleship Yamato: Final Chapter* - are different from this first TV series. Both are greyish colours, but the TV series *Yamato* has heavy, low-saturation, subdued grey-tone colouring. The Toei Doga-produced *Space Battleship Yamato* is overall blue-tinted grey. What circumstances led to this? I really don't know the truth, but I think one factor might be differences in paint manufacturers used.

The *Space Battleship Yamato* TV series was made with Taiyo Shikisai (太陽色彩) **company paints.** Meanwhile, Toei Doga was using **STAC (Saito Tele-Anima Colours Co.Ltf) (スタック)**** paints by this time. These two major paint manufacturers' colours actually have no compatibility. Against Taiyo Shikisai's many colours with overall low-saturation matte tones, STAC colours had overall vivid tones with fewer colours. If you painted the TV *Yamato*'s colours with the closest atmospheric STAC colours, that probably became the theatrical version's blue-tinted *Yamato*. That's what I think.

In the booklet included with this DVD box set, the original colouring settings from that time were published as reference material. So for the first time, I learnt the original *Yamato* colour direction and paint numbers. The basic ship body was **Z-4**, the ship bottom and smokestack red parts' basic was **Zm-1**. From the paint numbering system, I think these were probably colours created specifically for *Yamato*. Man, I was moved! In plastic model paint terms, that's "Japanese Navy warship colour" and "ship bottom colour" (laughs). After all, *Yamato* is imprinted with these colours in my mind, so I just can't like Toei Doga's "blue-tinted *Yamato*."

After the so-called *Space Battleship Yamato* boom, the three Toei Doga theatrical versions I mentioned earlier were made, and TV series 2 and 3 were also made, but for me, *Space Battleship Yamato* means the first TV series. There was a time when I thought "If new ones are made again, I want to participate too!" but now I want to cherish it as just one fan.

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